
Modeling Fragmented Prosopography: Historical Network Analysis and Archival Constraints in the 16th-century Greek Community of Venice

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Abstract

An essential component when researching identity expression in the early modern period is network analysis, whether stemming from kinship ties, spatial networks, or complex socio-economic relations. Analysing historical networks reveals the essence of belonging to a community that could span religious boundaries. Focusing on the Greek community in sixteenth-century Venice and overpassing the challenges of fragmented prosopography, the key question is how historical actors contextually altered their networks across different archival documents, drawing on notarial acts, confraternity registries, and Inquisition documents. The archival information derives from the Hellenic Institute in Venice and the Archivio di Stato di Venezia.

By leveraging a Digital Humanities methodology, the documents' information is semantically stored in a database, giving the advantage of conducting quantitative analysis, through which the patterns of networks emerge. To achieve the aforementioned objectives, the CIDOC-CRM ontology is employed providing a robust event-centric schema for the way networks are emerging through the documents, without flattening historical complexity (Doerr 2003; Lemercier, 2015). Important metadata of E39_Actor instances are included, and especially the place-names denoting the origins of a person, are modelled as a classification attribution and it is useful to trace the business and social networks of individuals. At the same time, the AAAo extension of the CRMbase is used to model the contextual nature of personal beliefs of adhering to a collective unit (Greek population in Venice) or the document's contextual information, which was once used for declaring specific bound-document networks. The model is designed specifically to detect contextual variation of identity, through network analysis, across document types, which network analysis offers reflection on how modelling choices affect interpretation (Schich et al. 2014). This way, persons, institutions, places of origin, legal roles, and confraternal affiliations are modelled as interconnected entities, yielding a multi-layered network analysis, and bipartite networks that extract prosopographical information, allowing the reconstruction of social and commercial ties across documentary contexts.

Preliminary results support the hypothesis of contextual expression of identity both on an institutional-related level and interpersonal affiliation level. On the one hand, confraternity registers and inquisition documents suggest a rigid adherence to a religious rite, favouring inter-Greek community relations based not only on kinship but also intra-cultural networks, especially in the case of condemnns expressed through inquisition documents. On the other hand, testaments, comprising personal and interpersonal narratives, as well as notarial acts

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of professions such as shipowner and merchant highlight the hybridity and social and cultural assimilation to the life in Venice, through business partnerships, friendships and legal facilitators.

Early modern history poses questions, especially for the expression of identity of a subcommunity. Although archival documents are characterised by partial scarcity, network analysis can assist in assessing the social agency of this community and how it influences the visibility of actors and connections, raising questions regarding comparability, narrative integration, and network representations. Network analysis in conjunction with digitally semantic information created, can reshape the way identity is studied under the social sphere and also assist in identifying the contextual identity expressions of early modern societies.

References

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